

Zaira Christa Barakat

BRAND DEVELOPMENT · CREATIVE STRATEGY · CULTURAL STRATEGY

London zcbarakat@gmail.com linkedin.com/in/zairachrista [The Archives by Zai](#)

PROFILE

Brand and cultural strategist in the making, translating cultural research into brand strategy, creative direction, and content across fashion, hospitality, and cultural events.

Tripled ticket sales year-on-year as Co-Creative Director of Oxford's largest student fashion event, and spent six years supporting content production and photoshoots for a hospitality brand – combining hands-on creative execution with an Oxford research background and an MA in Cultural and Creative Industries at King's College London.

Currently writing The Archives by Zai, a weekly essay project applying cultural and academic theory to fashion, nightlife, and brand culture, as a public, ongoing record of research-led strategic thinking.

EDUCATION

King's College London

2025 – 2026

MA Cultural and Creative Industries

University of Oxford, Somerville College

2022 – 2025

BA (Hons) Music, 2:1

EXPERIENCE – CREATIVE & BRAND STRATEGY

Zaira Christa Fashion Label

London · 2022 – Present

Founder & Creative Director

Built an independent fashion label from concept to catwalk, delivering two full seasonal collections and runway presentations by independently directing creative concept, garment production, styling, and casting.

Established the label's brand identity and digital presence, producing original campaign photography and editorial content that articulates a distinct creative point of view across every collection.

Oxford Fashion Gala

Oxford · 2023 – 2025

Co-Creative Director & Co-Marketing Director

Led end-to-end creative direction for Oxford's largest annual fashion event, producing a thematically unified show by directing concept development, casting, set design, and choreography from brief to live performance.

Tripled ticket sales year-on-year (a 200% increase) by designing and executing a multi-platform social campaign combining curated content, strategic collaborations, and a data-informed posting schedule.

Delivered a cohesive campaign identity across all audience-facing assets, copy, and promotional content, coordinating a volunteer team to execute the Gala's creative vision at scale.

Mandaloun Westfield

London · 2019 – 2025

Social Media & Content Assistant

Supported Mandaloun's social media content across Instagram and Facebook for six years, executing planned campaigns and day-to-day posts under the brand's marketing direction.

Assisted on photoshoots and seasonal campaign productions, helping coordinate shoots, prepare assets, and maintain visual consistency across platform-specific content.

Built six years of hands-on experience translating brand direction into finished content, developing a practical grounding in visual storytelling and platform-specific production.

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

Levi Strauss

London · 2025

Stylist

Exceeded sales targets during Black Friday, one of retail's highest-pressure trading periods, by delivering personalised styling consultations that lifted units per transaction (UPT) above the team benchmark.

The Reach Brasserie

London · 2025 – 2026

Bar Manager

Managed day-to-day operations in a high-footfall venue and designed a curated seasonal cocktail programme, balancing consistent brand standards, supplier relationships, and staff performance with cost efficiency and commercial viability.

PROJECTS

The Archives by Zai

2026 – Present

Independent Research & Essay Practice

Writing and publishing weekly essays applying cultural and academic theory to fashion, nightlife, and brand culture, building a public, research-led body of work as ongoing proof of strategic and cultural thinking.

SKILLS & COMPETENCIES

Cultural & Strategic Research

Cultural capital analysis, subcultural and trend research, brand positioning, audience insight, theory-to-strategy translation.

Creative Direction & Strategy

Art direction, visual storytelling, brand identity, campaign development, content planning, photoshoot production, Adobe Photoshop, Illustrator, InDesign, Premiere Pro.

Leadership & Operations

Team leadership, project management, cross-functional collaboration, client communication, budget awareness.

Languages

English (fluent), French (advanced), Arabic – Lebanese dialect (intermediate).